

02 — HR Questions and Answers

HR wants to know three things: **Can you do the job? Will you stay? Will you fit in the team?** Every answer should support one of these.

Keep each answer 30–60 seconds. Be positive. Never criticise a past company or manager.

A. About you

1. Tell me about yourself. Use the HR version in file 01, section 4.

2. Describe yourself in three words.

"Responsible, hard-working and curious. Responsible because I own my work till production. Hard-working because I come from a farming family where I saw daily effort. Curious because I keep learning — from jQuery to AWS Lambda to queues and caching."

3. What are your strengths?

"My first strength is ownership. At Atiya I handle features end to end — from requirement discussion to deployment and production support. My second strength is problem solving, especially performance problems. I brought a report query down from about 92 seconds to around 300 milliseconds. My third strength is adaptability. I've worked on healthcare, logistics, edtech, media and astrology projects, and with clients from four countries."

4. What is your weakness?

"Earlier I used to take on too many tasks at once because I didn't like saying no. Sometimes it put pressure on deadlines. Now I break work into smaller tasks, give realistic timelines, and tell my manager early if something is at risk. It has improved my planning a lot."

Other safe options: "I sometimes spend extra time polishing code — now I time-box it." / "Public speaking — I'm improving by doing demos to stakeholders."

5. How would your friends or colleagues describe you?

"As a hard-working and helpful person. Colleagues come to me for debugging help and deployment issues. Friends say I'm calm and fun-loving."

6. What motivates you?

"Seeing my work used by real people. When call-centre agents use my CRM every day, or a manager gets a report in seconds instead of minutes, that motivates me."

7. What are your hobbies?

"I play cricket, and I like guiding students who are starting in programming. I also like exploring new tech tools and reading about system design."

B. About the job and company

8. Why do you want to join our company? Research the company first (website, LinkedIn, Glassdoor, product). Then use this template:

"I read that your company works on [product/domain]. Your stack — Node.js, [MongoDB/PostgreSQL/AWS] — matches my experience. I'm especially interested because [scale/product/clients]. I want to work in a strong engineering team on a product with real users, and this role is backend-focused, which is exactly where I want to grow."

9. Why should we hire you?

"Three reasons. First, I have almost 4 years of hands-on Node.js backend experience — APIs, databases, queues, caching and deployment. Second, I've owned full projects in production, so I don't need hand-holding — I can take a requirement and ship it. Third, I've worked with international clients and different domains, so I adapt quickly. I'll be productive from the first few weeks."

10. What do you know about our company? Prepare 4 points: what they build, who their customers are, tech stack (from job description), recent news or funding.

11. Why are you looking for a change?

"I've learned a lot at Atiya — I own complete backend systems there. Now I want to work in a larger engineering team on a product at scale, with stronger code reviews and system design challenges. This role is backend-focused, which matches my long-term goal."

12. Where do you see yourself in 5 years?

"In 5 years I see myself as a senior backend engineer or tech lead — someone who designs systems, mentors juniors and owns important services. I want to grow in system design, distributed systems and cloud. I'd like to do that growth within one company for the long term."

13. What are your short-term and long-term goals?

"Short-term: join a good team, understand the product quickly and start delivering quality backend features. Long-term: become a strong backend architect who can design scalable systems and lead a team."

14. How long will you stay with us?

"I'm looking for a long-term role. As long as I'm learning, growing and contributing, I don't see a reason to move. My goal is to grow into a senior role in the same company."

15. What kind of work environment do you like?

"A team where people share knowledge, code is reviewed, and there is clear ownership. I'm comfortable in both fast-paced and structured environments."

C. Working style and pressure

16. Can you work under pressure?

"Yes. In production support at Atiya, when an issue affects agents during live calls, I have to fix it quickly. I stay calm, check logs first, find the root cause, apply a safe fix, and then document it. For example, when new code was not loading on IIS after deployment, I found that iisnode was not watching the source files, fixed the config and documented the restart steps."

17. Are you a team player?

"Yes. At Morpheme I worked with cross-functional teams, and on TorahAnytime I coordinated developers — assigning tickets, reviewing PRs and helping them when they got stuck. Even at Atiya, where I'm the main developer, I work closely with call-centre managers, QA and the IT team."

18. Can you work independently?

"Yes, that's one of my strengths. At Atiya I built 8 applications mostly on my own — from requirements to deployment. I also built ThePNAC.com and BikeShopShippers end to end."

19. Are you comfortable working late or on weekends?

"Yes, when the work needs it — like a production issue or a release. I plan my work to avoid it regularly, but I'm committed when it's important."

20. Are you willing to relocate?

"Yes, I'm open to relocation. I've already worked in Ahmedabad, Delhi and Greater Noida." *(Change if you are not open.)*

21. Remote, hybrid or office?

"I'm comfortable with all three. I've worked remotely with international clients using Slack, Jira and Zoom, and I'm also comfortable in the office."

22. How do you handle criticism?

"I take it positively. In code reviews, feedback helped me write cleaner code. I listen, ask questions if something is unclear, and improve. I don't take it personally."

23. How do you handle a conflict with a colleague?

"I talk directly and calmly, focus on the problem and not the person, and use data. On one project there was a disagreement about retrying a dialer API automatically. I explained the risk — a retry could call a customer twice — and proposed a safer option. We agreed on it and I documented the decision."

24. How do you prioritise when you have many tasks?

"First production issues, then deadline-based tasks, then improvements. I list tasks in Jira or a simple note, estimate them, and agree priorities with my manager when two things clash."

25. How do you keep yourself updated?

"I follow Node.js release notes, read engineering blogs, watch system design videos and try new tools in small projects. For example, I learned BullMQ and Redis caching by using them in real projects."

D. Achievements and failures

26. What is your biggest achievement?

"Replacing the legacy ASP.NET CRM at Atiya with a Node.js and React system without changing the database. It had 460+ tables. I wrote a script that generated 463 model files from the SQL schema, which saved weeks of work. Today agents use it daily inside the dialer."

27. Tell me about a failure.

"In one of my early projects, I kept environment files with credentials inside the repository to move faster. Later I realised it was a security risk. I learned from it — now I keep only a `.env.example` in git, inject secrets on the server, and rotate keys if they were exposed."

28. Tell me about a mistake you learned from.

"Once I built a reporting feature that read data from a child table. Results were always empty for the last 30 minutes. I found that the table was filled by an hourly ETL job. I learned to always check how and when the source data is written before building on it. I switched to the live parent table and documented it."

29. Have you ever led a team?

"Yes, on TorahAnytime at Morpheme. I assigned tickets, reviewed and merged pull requests, guided developers and handled production deployments for the Israeli client."

E. Offer and joining

30. What is your current CTC?

"My current CTC is [X] LPA fixed." (Say the exact number. It will be checked with salary slips.)

31. What is your expected CTC?

"Based on my almost 4 years of experience, my backend skills and the market for this role, I'm expecting [Y] LPA. I'm open to discussion based on the overall offer and growth." *Tip: research the range on Glassdoor/AmbitionBox for "Node.js developer 4 years" in your city. A 30–50% hike over current is normal for a switch.*

32. What is your notice period?

"My notice period is [30/60/90] days. I can try to get early release if needed."

33. Do you have any other offers?

If yes: "Yes, I have one offer, but this role is my first preference because [reason]." If no: "I'm in process with a few companies, but I'm most interested in this role."

34. Why did you change companies so often? → See file 08, it has a full answer.

35. Are you overqualified for this role?

"I don't think so. I have the right experience to start contributing quickly, and there's still a lot I want to learn here, like [their tech/scale]."

F. Classic "thinking" questions

36. What is the difference between hard work and smart work?

"Hard work is putting in effort and time. Smart work is choosing the right method so the effort gives more results. For example, instead of hand-writing 463 model files, I wrote a script to generate them. Best results come from both together."

37. What is the difference between confidence and overconfidence?

"Confidence is believing in yourself based on preparation. Overconfidence is believing you're right without preparation or ignoring risks. Confidence says 'I can do this'; overconfidence says 'I don't need to test this'."

38. What is success for you?

"Success is when my work solves a real problem and people use it. Personally, it's growing every year and supporting my family."

39. Who inspires you?

"My father. He's a farmer and works hard every day without complaining. He taught me discipline and patience."

40. What makes you angry?

"I don't get angry easily. What disappoints me is careless work that breaks production — so I prefer clear processes and testing."

41. Would you lie for the company?

"No. I'll always be loyal to the company, but honesty is important. I'll look for an honest solution that also protects the company."

42. If you won a lottery, would you still work?

"Yes. I enjoy building software, and work gives me learning and purpose, not just money."

43. What if we reject you?

"I'll take it as feedback, ask where I can improve, and work on it. I'd also like to apply again in the future."

44. Rate yourself in Node.js out of 10.

"I'd say 7.5 out of 10. I'm strong in APIs, databases, async patterns, queues and deployment. I want to go deeper in Node internals and large distributed systems — that's what I'm working on."

45. Do you have any questions for us? — Always say YES. See file 08, section D.